

ARIA

Abi Harrison-Nye

What is it for?

ARIA stands for 'Accessible Rich Internet Applications'. ARIA is a set of roles and attributes that enable the web to be more accessible for users with disabilities. ARIA adds to HTML. It lets common web app interactions be passed to assistive technologies when there is no other way to do this.

NOTE: Not using ARIA is always better than using ARIA badly. Bad use of ARIA can completely mess up a website for users of assistive technology. ARIA attributes should only be used as a last resort when semantic elements can't achieve the desired result.

How to support it

- `aria-label` & `aria-labelledby`: Adds an accessible label to elements that do not have visible text. For example, a search button with only an icon should include an `aria-label` clarifying it. Use it on interactive elements or landmarks, not plain divs or text
- `aria-hidden`: Hides elements from screen readers without removing them visually. This is ideal for decorative or redundant elements
- ARIA roles add semantic meaning to content. These should be avoided when there is semantic HTML that can provide the same meaning (e.g. don't use `role=listitem` and instead use an `<li>`)

Useful Links

W3C - Rules of ARIA
mdn web docs - ARIA
List of ARIA attributes
Accessibility essentials every front-end developer should know
What I Wish Someone Told Me When I Was Getting Into ARIA
List of ARIA roles